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PROPORTIONATELY IRATE
An OBC Mahasabha rally seeking 27 per cent quotas; inset, CM Mohan Yadav



MADHYA PRADESH

QUOTA QUANDARY

The Mohan Yadav regime stands unreservedly for OBC quotas, but it creates political unease among the BJP's traditional base

By **Rahul Noronha**

DO CASTE-BASED QUOTAS FINISH MERIT OR CREATE FUTURE MERIT? Depends on who you ask, but no one will deny that the juncture at which a fresh quota comes into play tends to be a conflictual one for society—and politics. Madhya Pradesh is at one such point, if the Mohan Yadav government has its way in a case being heard in the Supreme Court. In fact, not unexpectedly, parties across the spectrum back the hiking of job and educational quotas for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) from 14 to 27 per cent. Again, not unexpectedly, only some student bodies are protesting.

But therein lies the dilemma for the ruling BJP. Its stand has massive political ramifications, with the affidavits filed by the state in the SC furnishing arguments supporting the hike causing heartburn among the forward castes—the BJP's traditional base. Socially, too, signs of animus are visible in the Gwalior-Chambal region, where caste identities are most acute. An extra delicacy attaches in Yadav's case because he himself illustrates the pro-OBC push in leadership roles made by major parties in the state. Though, in all fairness, he may have had little wiggle room on the issue.

AN EYE ON THE VOTE

It was the Congress that first tried to harvest OBC sympathies through this policy, when then CM Kamal Nath announced it in March 2019, just ahead of the Lok Sabha election. As it happened, that poll outcome reflected no particular gratitude from OBC groups for the Congress, but the party continued to defend the move—and still hovers in the background as a potential claimant to the trophy. If anything, Rahul Gandhi's all-out shift to the social justice plank makes that threat more manifest. So, taking the lead made sense for Yadav.

He did so in August-end, convening an all-party meet, then using the consensus there to fight the case at the apex court. That case was born in 2019, soon after the Kamal Nath policy move, when a group of students—Ashita Dubey and others—challenged it in the high court soon on the grounds that it would violate the 50 per cent mark set by the Supreme Court's landmark Indira Sawhney verdict of 1992. Pending a final verdict, it ruled that the old reservation levels would continue for the medical PG exam. This January, the then CJI Suresh Kaith decided to club all petitions in the matter. The state government acted with alacrity and